

But this chapter isn't for the average family with kids, whatever "average" means in the 1980s. This chapter is for *your* American family with kids. Vicki and I have no children, but we know something about your family. Your family's dad, mom, or both want to retire young. Your family has quite a bit more net worth than average, perhaps \$400,000 or more. The Census Bureau reports that in 1984 "married-couple households had a median net worth of . . . about four times that of female-maintained households and five times that of male-maintained households." So your family's dad and mom are probably married to each other. The Census Bureau also reports that "householders with a college education had nearly twice the net worth of those who graduated from high school but did not attend college." So your family's head most likely graduated from college. You want your kids to have the same chance of getting a good education as you had.

The hypothetical Doe family from Pasadena may be something like yours. Dad Doe, an account executive in J. Walter Thompson's Los Angeles office, pries his eyes open at 6:30 A.M., turns down the jazz music on his clock-radio, pulls on his swimming trunks, and heads for the heated swimming pool. After ten laps he drips his way through the kitchen, pours himself a cup of coffee, and turns on the TV. The sounds of *Good Morning America* mingle with the heavy metal blaring from 17-year-old Alex's clock-radio. Dad dresses, gulps a second cup of coffee, and eats a pop-up tart in one smooth, well-rehearsed motion. His Mazda RX-7 is roaring down the Pasadena freeway, slicing through traffic, before he realizes his day has begun.

Mom rolls out of bed and makes her way to the bathroom medicine cabinet. With heavy eyelids, she debates whether two aspirin will get her through the morning. She takes three, claws into the wreckage of Alex's room, and shuts off his radio. The silence wakes him up. She pounds on 14-year-old Monica's door and yells at her to hurry in the bathroom.